



MONTHLY UPDATE

Zambia: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-08 · 49 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

The election was the month's frame. The cyber security agency [warned against hate speech and cyberbullying after the poll](#), observer missions [reported on the digital systems used in the general election](#), the rights commission considered 105 alleged violations in the election period and resolved 62, and a survey [put public support for media freedom and a watchdog role on the record](#). A consent judgment [obliges the regulator to give a reason for any internet interruption within 36 hours](#); no interruption is on the record for this election.

Collection and connectivity moved in the districts. Eight of 116 councils [are on the e-council platform](#), a district administration [was connected to the government wide area network](#), and the state ICT institute [set a national standard for border-post connectivity and commissioned an independent ICT audit](#). The regulator [blocked 43,500 SIM cards linked to mobile-money fraud in the first half of the year](#).

Three standing positions entered the record this month rather than moving in it. The state technology institute [publishes its national authentication and access-control service, running single sign-on, OpenID Connect, multi-factor authentication and passwordless credentials for electronic government](#) — the service the passport and voucher systems already depend on, described for the first time. The standards bureau [puts more than 50 international standards adopted as national ones within a catalogue of more than 6,500](#). And the citizen support portal [reached the labour ministry, whose staff were trained to handle cases through it in districts with no physical office](#), while a single rural primary school [had its computer laboratory connected by satellite](#) against a national target of 2,500 schools by December.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The national artificial-intelligence strategy has reached the end of the period it was written for. The technology ministry's permanent secretary [says it is nearing the end of its cycle and is due for review](#). A strategy due for review before its successor exists is the position the base can state; no review terms of reference, timetable or drafting body is published.

Data protection

The data-protection regulator exists and travels; nothing in the base shows it acting. It joined a multi-sectoral delegation to the continental identity conference, and on 31 July [nine civil society organisations asked it to examine the source of the contact list behind SMS messages sent to social cash transfer beneficiaries](#) before the 13 August

election. No response from the Office is on the record. No registration count, enforcement decision, fine, breach notification, guidance note or annual report is held for it at any date. The Data Protection Act 2021 remains in force and was [named by the information ministry on 18 July as one of three instruments regulating online communications, cybersecurity and personal data](#); the reported Cabinet intention to repeal it has produced nothing on the record in sixteen months.

What is being built for it is a system rather than a case. The World Bank-financed acceleration project [opened tender on 10 August, closing 21 August, for a digital data-protection compliance management system to serve the Commission](#), to integrate with the government service bus and payment gateway and to meet ISO/IEC 27001, ISO/IEC 27701 and WCAG 2.1 AA, alongside a [parallel tender to review the national data-protection guidelines and compliance frameworks](#). Tenders rather than awards, and neither states a value, a delivery date, or the caseload the system would manage.

Standards

The standards bureau states its own position rather than reporting a change. Its service page [puts more than 50 international standards adopted as Zambian Standards, within a catalogue of more than 6,500 national standards across sectors including information and communication technology](#). The page carries no date, so the figures are dated to retrieval, and no breakdown by sector or year of adoption is published — an adoption count with no series behind it.

The trust layer under the interoperability standards was stood up. The communications regulator [operationalised the National Digital Trust Anchor in its capacity as national root certification authority, the framework issuing and verifying digital certificates and signatures establishing the identity of people and organisations, on the legal base of the electronic communications and transactions statute](#). No certificate count, subordinate-authority list, accreditation route or fee schedule is published, and the launch reaches the base through a news report rather than the regulator's own notice — which for a root certification authority is the one thing a relying party would want to be able to check.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The same Postal and Courier Services Bill consultation — the only open public call for written comment on a Zambian instrument the wiki holds for the whole window — closed three days after the call for written submissions was reported, with no submission count, published response or consultation report held.

On 1 August the Human Rights Commission disclosed that its case review meeting had considered 105 alleged violations linked to the election period, of which 62 were resolved administratively.

The election itself, on 13 August, produced the fullest external account of the country's digital systems the base holds. Observer missions recorded a [hybrid digital and manual voter-registration system with an online pre-registration portal, logging 8,786,300 registered voters, up 25% since 2021](#). A domestic coalition [found election-day process largely transparent but flagged an online-only accreditation system that blocked 11 accredited monitors, and the electoral commission's refusal to share the voters register](#). The European mission found online free expression unduly curtailed under the 2025 Cyber Security Act amid arrests for speech offences, and a regional media institute [recorded a journalist detained for two weeks under the Cyber Crimes Act and judged the access-to-information law and decriminalised defamation paper victories undermined by the two 2025 statutes](#). These are preliminary statements; no final report, government response or commission account of the accreditation and register decisions is held.

Finance

New investments

On 27 July a domestic digital lender [reported more than K500 million lent to over 120,000 customers since founding, and committed a further K500 million over the next decade](#) — a forward intention by the lender itself, with no external financier named.

External money made a smaller and vaguer offer. On 11 August the United Kingdom [opened expressions of interest for a Southern Africa science and technology accelerator worth up to GBP2.5m to March 2030](#), naming Zambia with Zimbabwe as the first year's focus and South Africa as the programme's primary one. No Zambian allocation is stated, and the delivery consortium has not been chosen.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

A government-owned shared 4G network for public institutions was launched at Ndola Teaching Hospital on 15 July 2026, run by the state ICT institute with three named partners and the health ministry ([launch account](#)). The reported outcomes are clinician accounts at the launch site; no baseline or measured result is held.

On 5 August the institute confirmed that connectivity gaps persist at Nakonde, Victoria Falls, Kazungula and Chirundu, and set a single national standard through the government network of tiered 10 to 100 Mbps bandwidth, dual links with automatic failover and enterprise-grade firewalls. A trade facilitation body has commissioned an audit of ICT infrastructure at five border posts; no budget, timetable or completion date is published, and the audit precedes the procurement rather than following it ([status update](#)).

The technology ministry [put the country at about 26.2 million mobile subscriptions in 2025, up from 23.2 million in 2024, with about 14.7 million mobile internet subscriptions](#) - its own figures, given in a seminar address rather than a regulator publication.

A further Northern Province district administration was connected in August, and the account is unusually specific about what a connection reached. After the provincial ICT unit installed connectivity at Lupososhi District Administration and ran a virtual orientation on the national portal and two office collaboration tools, an official [printed a road-tax document from his own office instead of travelling to Kasama for it, days before it expired](#). It is one office and one document: no district count, schedule or cost for the programme is published.

A second account of the same period puts [internet subscriptions at 14.7m in 2025 against 10.4m in 2021, and mobile population coverage at 95% over 2022 to 2025](#). The coverage figure is government-reported and does not reconcile with the ministry's own separate claim for the same period — a reminder that every coverage number here comes from the same source as the target it is measured against.

Energy

Power at the tower is where a network's reliability is decided, and one operator put money against it. The tower company INFRATEL [says it has invested US\\$5 million in power resilience at mobile sites, deploying high-powered thermal batteries and upgrading solar plant](#). The figure is the company's own; no site count, no before-and-after outage measure and no independent verification is in the record held.

Cybersecurity

The Ministry of Information and Media declared the Cyber Crimes Act No. 4 of 2025 fully operational on 18 July 2026, warning that recording, publishing or distributing private communications without authorisation could bring prosecution and singling out public servants on confidential information. Compliance obligations were stated as extending to financial institutions, telecommunications operators, digital platforms, mobile money providers and e-commerce businesses ([enforcement account](#)). The declaration falls twenty-six days before the general election of 13 August. No prosecution, charge or conviction count has been published.

Three days earlier the cyber security agency had urged journalists to learn the cyber laws, framing them as protection for media houses against ransomware and disruption.

The regulator reported on 4 August that it had deactivated 43,500 SIM cards linked to mobile-money fraud and secured K19.8 million between January and June 2026, on consumer reports through a short code, with no breakdown by operator and no prior-period comparison ([regulator figures](#)).

DPI

Data Exchange

The government service bus, the central integration layer, onboarded eight of 116 local authorities from June 2026 and now carries more than 400 government services with over K8.8 billion collected cumulatively across the service bus, payment gateway, national portal and payment platform ([collection figures](#); [Accountant General's office](#)).

A register of a different kind opened alongside it. Zambia [launched a fully digital National Carbon Registry on 7 August](#), embedded in the national measurement, reporting and verification system and interoperable with Article 6 of the Paris Agreement, developed under a donor programme with a UN climate centre, a consulting group and a green growth institute. No public access, transaction count, custodian ministry or disclosure rule for its holdings is stated — which for a registry whose purpose is to make carbon claims checkable is the question it exists to answer.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The national authentication service is described by the body that runs it. The state technology institute [publishes it as an operational national authentication and access-control service, with single sign-on, OpenID Connect, multi-factor authentication and passwordless credentials for electronic government services](#). Named protocols and a running service are a stronger artefact than most identity positions on this ledger; the page carries no date, so the position is dated to retrieval, and no user count, uptime figure or list of relying services is published.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 27 July a vendor manager stated on the record that the National Financial Switch's intended reduction in customer transaction costs has not happened yet, that the central bank is only now focusing on it, and that the electronic clearing house is not yet live on the regional instant-payment scheme ([switch account](#)).

Retail participation in the securities market is the one digital adoption figure the month produced: registered users of the exchange's mobile trading application [rose to 51,791 in July from 49,611 in June](#). It is the exchange's own count of registered users, not of active traders or funded accounts.

The regional rail above the domestic one acquired its rules. The regional clearing house [published the scheme rulebook for instant low-cost cross-border retail payments, with a gender audit and strategy to 2030 drawn from research along the corridor with Malawi](#). No Zambian transaction volume, participant count or fee schedule is published.

Acceptance also widened from outside. A commercial bank and an international card scheme [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Zambia on 19 August](#), settling in local currency, US dollars or both; the merchant count is given for the nine markets together and not for Zambia.

The account base under the inclusion figure was stated: [14.7m registered mobile money accounts in 2024 on the monetary fund's financial access survey, of which 77% hold a balance, against one adult in five holding any account at all in 2011](#), with the central bank phasing out cheque clearing behind it. Registered accounts are not people, and the balance share is the only measure of activity the base holds against the count.

Registries

A [national carbon registry went live on 8 August](#) in its first phase, with every carbon-credit transaction in Zambia required to pass through it, administered by the environmental agency and linked to the national monitoring system and the UNFCCC accounting platform; a second phase is to add voluntary-market registration. No address, operating rules, access terms or naming of the legal instrument is published, and the counts given at the launch — more than 90 projects at stages of approval, and bilateral agreements with Sweden, Norway and Switzerland — are the permanent secretary's own. A [national spatial data infrastructure policy and portal were launched](#) on open-source software, cited as underpinning land mapping and artisanal mining licensing, with no dataset count, licence terms or usage figure held and the policy document itself not held. The land administration system is unchanged, and the Minister of Lands told Parliament that its [predecessor ran with no maintenance contract from 31 March 2022, creating a conduit for corruption](#).

Sectoral management information systems

An emergency outbreak response platform [entered two days of user-acceptance testing](#). User-acceptance testing is the last stage before a system becomes someone's responsibility in an emergency; no go-live date, participating facilities or data flow is published.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The movement is at the far end of the network rather than at the centre. The e-government agency's Northern Province unit is [onboarding government employees in Mpulungu, Mbala and Lupososhi districts onto an e-payslip self-service portal](#), replacing manual payslip distribution with round-the-clock access to employment records, and has connected the Lupososhi district administration to the Government Wide Area Network and given it a wireless access point so officials can use internet calling and digital communication platforms rather than unreliable mobile coverage. The same unit is inspecting government office equipment and briefing officials on the Government Office Equipment Standards, which cover acquisition, registration, maintenance, use and disposal. No enrolment count, coverage figure or completion date accompanies any of it, so what is on record is a method reaching three districts.

The office platform was ordered across the whole of government. The Secretary to the Cabinet [directed every government institution to adopt the Smart Office Platform and instructed the Smart Zambia Institute to report to his office by the end of October 2026 on the onboarding of ministries, provinces, spending agencies, state-owned enterprises and other public institutions](#), the direction given at the handover of the system to the airports corporation at Chongwe. It is a direction with a reporting deadline rather than a measured rollout: the base has carried the platform as a health-ministry pilot since 2025 and holds no count of institutions onboarded.

The office system moved beyond ministries for the first time. The airports corporation [became the first state-owned enterprise onboarded, the system commissioned and handed over by the Secretary to the Cabinet, with a further 406 staff to be trained across its stations by the end of November](#) — the same directive that told every government institution to adopt it now reaching the commercial arm of the state.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The eight onboarded local authorities returned about K21.7 million in their first month, for property rates, business levies and permits, with one city council urging business and property owners to use the platform on stated grounds of minimising revenue leakages ([collection figures](#)).

Connectivity followed the collection: the state ICT institute [equipped a town council with ICT and telepresence equipment](#). It is one council of 116, and no cost, rollout schedule or list of the rest is published.

Rural digital data capture

One rural school was connected. An operator [connected a primary school's computer laboratory in the Chipapa community by satellite](#), a completed deployment rather than a commitment. Set against the education ministry's own target for schools connected to reliable internet by the end of this year, it is one school with four months to run, and no progress count against that target is published.

Technology

AI

The month's artificial-intelligence entry is a competition rather than a capability. Applications [closed on 18 August for an AI for Public Good Challenge run with a UN development agency](#). No entry count, prize, selection criterion or follow-on funding is published, and the base still holds no national artificial-intelligence laboratory, model or compute position.

ICT Industry

The third edition of a continental diversity report puts [29% of Zambian startups sampled with at least one female co-founder, the highest of any country covered, and 22.6% with a female chief executive](#), against a continental 19.2% female co-founded from a sample of more than 3,000. The underlying report is not held; only the trade-press account is.

Innovation ecosystem

A donor-funded accelerator began staffing up: a private hub [called for facilitators and group coaches for a twelve-month incubator running masterclasses, group coaching and access to funding for digital startups](#). No cohort size, budget or start date is stated, and the government innovation fund the base looked for is still not held.

Capacity

Literacy

The state ICT institute, with the International Telecommunication Union and the youth ministry, [handed computers, a projector and an industrial printer to the Mpika Youth Resource Centre](#), with two further handovers named. No cost, contract term, procurement route or trainee count is published.

Training and skills

Training in the window is a private programme rather than a state one. A ride-hailing company's fellowship [expanded to six African countries and selected its 2026 cohort](#), this country among them. No Zambian intake figure, curriculum or placement outcome is published, and no state training total sits on the ledger for the month.

Inclusion

Access to services

The citizen support portal reached a ministry that has no offices in much of the country. Labour and social security staff [were trained to handle labour cases through the portal, extending it to districts with no physical office](#). Where a portal substitutes for a counter that was never there, the question is what happens to a claimant without connectivity — and no fallback, case volume or resolution figure is published for it.

Data

Use of satellite data

Weather data for aviation is being examined rather than improved. The Civil Aviation Authority and the International Civil Aviation Organisation [launched an assessment to strengthen aviation weather data](#). What the assessment starts from is not stated: the record held carries nothing on what meteorological data Zambia currently produces, from which sources, or how it reaches the people flying.

Geopolitics

China activities

A [seminar on China-Zambia artificial-intelligence cooperation](#) covered localising artificial-intelligence solutions to Zambian conditions and partnering with universities on curricula, and a ministry director and the Chinese ambassador [discussed digital infrastructure, emerging technologies, skills and research](#). No agreement, value, timetable or named institution follows from either.

India activities

India enters the record as a destination rather than a donor. Officials from the digital and ICT sector and line ministries [joined delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda and Sierra Leone and the African Union Commission on a south-south learning mission hosted by the United Nations Development Programme](#), studying India's digital public infrastructure and the institutions that built it; [the state government of Karnataka received them in Bengaluru on 1 September](#). No agreement, financing, technology transfer or follow-on commitment is named on either side.

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